



Identifying when to use a semicolon

Adverbs such as *however*, *accordingly*, *besides*, and *therefore* can also be used as conjunctions to join two main clauses. Unlike coordinating conjunctions and subordinators, these adverbs must be preceded by a semicolon and followed by a comma.

two main clauses
She was confident. She hadn't cut the hedge before.

coordinating conjunction separating two main clauses
She was confident, **but** she hadn't cut the hedge before.

This adverb is being used as a conjunction, so it must be preceded by a semicolon and followed by a comma.
She was confident; **however**, she hadn't cut the hedge before.

Coordinating multiple subjects

When a coordinating conjunction is used to link two main clauses with different subjects, a comma should be placed before the conjunction. This helps to show where one main clause ends and another begins.

first main clause first subject
Flora tried to water her roses and sunflowers, but the hose burst.
A comma and coordinating conjunction separate the two main clauses.
second subject second main clause

sunflowers, **but** the hose burst.
tree **because** they were too tall.

Subordinators

Subordinators or subordinating conjunctions are used to connect words, phrases, and clauses of unequal importance. A subordinate clause adds information to a main clause, explaining why, where, or when something is happening. Subordinate clauses start with subordinators like *before*, *if*, *because*, *although*, and *while*, and can be placed at the beginning or end of a sentence.

main clause
She cut both the hedge and the tree because they were too tall.
subordinator
The subordinate clause explains why Flora cut the hedge.
subordinator
A subordinate clause can also go at the start of a sentence.
Before she started, she put on some gloves.
A comma is needed to separate the two clauses when the subordinator is at the start of a sentence.
main clause